THE GHOSTWRITER FROM THE 6TH DIMENSION

ACT TWO

Written by

[Writer]

Original screenplay
Act Two, Draft 1. Continues from Act One (page 22). Act Three follows.
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INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - MORNING

Sun pours through the window over the sink. Dust hangs in the light. The glass is clean: no fog, no letters.

Theo lifts his head from his folded arms at the table. June sits across from him, a bowl of cereal untouched in front of her, reading a cream page. A second lies beside the bowl.

JUNE
You said you were home.

THEO
I was home.

June holds up the page.

JUNE
It says you went in.

Theo reaches for it. June pulls it back.

THEO
June.

JUNE
I looked it up. People forget the worst thing that ever happened to them. Their brain puts it away. Then it comes back in pieces.

THEO
Where did you look it up?

JUNE
The internet, Dad.

She lays the page flat and smooths it with her palm.

JUNE (CONT'D)
Maybe this is your brain giving it back.

Theo looks at the page, then at her face. She is waiting for him to say yes.

JUNE (CONT'D)
You saved Aunt Nell.

Theo opens his mouth. Closes it.

JUNE (CONT'D)
You didn't say no.

THEO
Eat your cereal.

June eats, grinning at him over the spoon.

Theo crosses to the refrigerator for milk and stops. The photograph under the lobster magnet is different.

Theo at nine sits on a boulder at the quarry with a small girl on his shoulders. A red jacket hangs over his arm. No taller boy. No bicycle.

He lifts the magnet and takes the photo down. On the back, in faded pencil: THEO + NELL, AUG. '87. The print is yellowed, creased at one corner.

THEO (CONT'D)
There was another boy in this.

JUNE
What boy?

THEO
Tall. On a bike. Red jacket.

JUNE
That's the red jacket. It's on your arm.

THEO
That isn't mine.

JUNE
You wore it all summer. Everybody knows that.

She goes back to her cereal. Theo studies the photograph. He rubs his thumb across the small girl's face.

He smiles. He wipes the smile off his mouth with his hand. It comes back.

INT. KETTLE HOLLOW PUBLIC LIBRARY - DAY

One room: oak tables, green-shaded lamps, a microfilm reader in the corner.

A LIBRARIAN (70s), cardigan, half-glasses on a beaded chain, threads a reel onto the machine while Theo waits.

LIBRARIAN
Slate Valley News, August 1987. Only one person ever asks for this reel. Marit Arvidsen. Every August.

THEO
Who is she?

LIBRARIAN
His mother.

She cranks the handle. Newsprint slides across the screen and stops on a front page.

BOY, 13, DIES SAVING NEIGHBOR GIRL

The photograph shows a boy in a baseball cap. Theo leans in. The face breaks into black dots.

Tomas Arvidsen of Quarry Road drowned Friday after pulling a five-year-old from the quarry pond. The girl, Eleanor Lindqvist, was treated for exposure. Her brother, Theodore, 9, was at home and did not witness the accident.

Theo reads the last line twice. He exhales.

The librarian reads over his shoulder and nods at an oak table by the window.

LIBRARIAN (CONT'D)
Tomas sat right there every afternoon that summer. Read everything in the juvenile stacks. Wrote in the margins in pencil. I spent half my life erasing him.

THEO
Why did you erase him?

LIBRARIAN
They're library books. I'd give a great deal to find one of those margins now.

THEO
Was he the type to jump in?

LIBRARIAN
Tomas would jump in after anybody. Didn't stop to think. That was the whole trouble with him.

Theo looks at the dots where the face should be.

THEO
Could I have a copy?

The librarian presses a button. The machine hums and a printout curls from the slot. Theo folds it into his coat.

LIBRARIAN
Your sister was lucky.

THEO
So I read.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

One lamp. The laptop is open on the table. Beside it lies the library printout, face up: BOY, 13, DIES SAVING NEIGHBOR GIRL.

Two cream pages sit in front of Theo. He looks at the printout. He looks at the pages.

He turns the printout face down.

He types. The first line of page two, then the second. The pencil in the wall scratches in time with the keys. The screen reads Page 3 of 3.

He types the last word of the last page: and. His fingers keep moving. A new sentence fills the screen.

I carried her up the slate on my back. Her lips were blue. Her hair was a rope of black water.

The lamp turns amber. The scratching in the wall quickens.

I put my mouth over hers and blew, the way I'd seen it done on television. Nothing. I blew again.

Theo's shoulders drop. He grins at the screen.

She coughed the whole pond out of her and into my mouth. It tasted of iron.

The clock over the back door reads 1:12. The screen reads Page 14 of 14.

The clock reads 2:50. Page 22 of 22.

The clock reads 4:20. Page 31 of 31. The scratching and the keys match beat for beat.

She said my name. Not Theodore. Theo. The way she always said it, like a question.

Theo reaches for his mug. His sleeve slides up. On the inside of his left wrist, a line of brown-black ink surfaces under the skin, in the handwriting of the pages:

I reached.

He sets the mug down. Rubs the line with his thumb. It stays. He spits on his thumb and rubs again. It stays.

He pulls his cuff over it and keeps typing.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

Rain at the window. Theo types without looking at the keys, his eyes red-rimmed.

June sits across from him with a school worksheet. Her cereal bowl is empty. She taps her pencil on the table.

JUNE
Dad.

THEO
Mm.

JUNE
I need the street we lived on in the city. For the transfer form.

Theo's fingers keep moving.

THEO
Sure. It's--

His fingers stop.

THEO (CONT'D)
It's...

JUNE
Dad.

THEO
Give me a second.

He stares at the screen. His lips shape the first sound of a word. No word follows.

JUNE
Perry Street.

Theo looks at her.

JUNE (CONT'D)
Where you wrote "A Room Called Afternoon." In the back bedroom, by the radiator.

THEO
"A Room Called--"

He turns toward the bookshelf. Two of his paperbacks stand there with a gap between them, wide enough for a third. June follows his eyes.

THEO (CONT'D)
"Slate." "The Understory."

JUNE
And the one in the middle.

Theo looks at the gap. He looks at June.

THEO
June, I don't--

June stands. She picks up her worksheet and goes upstairs. Her footsteps cross the ceiling. Her voice comes through the boards, small and clear.

JUNE (O.S.)
Mom? It's me.

Theo sits. He pulls his cuff down over the line on his wrist.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

The clock reads 2:07. One lamp. Theo clicks SEND on an email. The screen reads: To: Priya Raman. Subject: Pages. Attachment: 40 pages.

His phone buzzes across the table. PRIYA RAMAN. He answers.

THEO
Priya.

PRIYA (V.O.)
I read all forty. I'm in my kitchen in my pajamas. I'm crying into a bowl of cereal.

THEO
Is it any good?

PRIYA (V.O.)
Is it any good. Theo. It's the book. It's the one you've been not writing for eight years.

THEO
It's pages.

PRIYA (V.O.)
You went into the water.

THEO
That's what it says.

PRIYA (V.O.)
No, I mean you said it. At the PEN dinner. Table six, 2013. You held up your hand like this--

A rustle on the line.

PRIYA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
--and you said, "I reached for her and she was already gone." I've been waiting twelve years for you to write it.

THEO
I never said that.

PRIYA (V.O.)
Theo. I was next to you. You squeezed my hand under the table.

Theo says nothing. His right hand is raised, palm out. He looks at it and lowers it.

PRIYA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
The board meets on the first. Whatever you're doing, keep doing it.

THEO
Priya--

PRIYA (V.O.)
Don't stop. Love you.

She hangs up. Theo sets the phone down. He pushes his sleeve to the elbow. Two lines of ink run down his forearm:

I reached.
There was nobody on the ledge.

He stares at the second line.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

A car door slams outside. The back door opens.

MARA HALE (45) stands in the doorway: long gray coat, reading glasses pushed up into dark hair, a hard-shell case in one hand. Rain beads on her shoulders.

JUNE (O.S.)
Mom!

June runs in and hugs her. Mara holds her with one arm and keeps her eyes on Theo.

MARA
You look terrible.

THEO
You didn't have to come.

MARA
Five hours. She called me.

JUNE
I wasn't crying.

MARA
She wasn't crying, she says.

Mara sets the case on the table. Theo's sleeves are rolled to the elbow. Mara looks at his forearm.

MARA (CONT'D)
What is that?

THEO
A pen leaked.

Mara takes his wrist and turns it to the window. She pulls a loupe from her coat pocket and bends over the ink.

MARA
That's not ink.

THEO
Mara.

MARA
It's under the skin. No inflammation, no needle marks. It sits in the epidermis the way iron-gall sits in paper.

She lets go of his wrist.

MARA (CONT'D)
It's on you the way it's on paper.

THEO
Don't.

MARA
Show me the pages.

Theo goes to the bookshelf and takes down SLATE. He opens it and removes page one. Mara pulls white cotton gloves from her pocket, puts them on, and takes the page by its edges.

She holds it to the window. She runs a gloved thumb along the deckled edge.

MARA (CONT'D)
Cotton and linen rag. Nineteenth century. No watermark. The fibers are swollen. It's wet from the inside.

THEO
It's damp.

MARA
Damp is on the surface. This is in the sheet.

She turns the page over.

MARA (CONT'D)
There's something on the back.

THEO
Bleed-through.

MARA
Bleed-through doesn't have a second hand. This is pencil. It's pressed into the fibers. Someone wrote this from the other side.

THEO
I can't read it.

Mara holds the page at an angle to the light. Her lips move. She stops.

MARA
Neither can I.

She looks at him.

MARA (CONT'D)
You only ever read the front.

Theo flinches. Mara lays the page in the case. She takes the top sheet from the table and lays it beside the first.

MARA (CONT'D)
I'm taking these to the lab.

THEO
Those are mine.

MARA
They're evidence of something. I don't know what yet.

June stands between them.

JUNE
Can I stay?

Mara looks at Theo. Looks at June.

MARA
Nine o'clock every night, you call me. Every night.

JUNE
Okay.

Mara picks up the case.

MARA
(to Theo)
If she calls me like that again, I'm taking her.

THEO
She won't.

MARA
I know. She doesn't cry. She just tells me the facts.

She kisses the top of June's head and goes out into the rain.

INT. ALDER HILL - NURSES' STATION - NIGHT

Night lights. The corridor is empty, every door shut. Ellie sits at the station with a chart and a cup of tea.

Theo stands at the desk in a wet coat.

THEO
I know it's late.

ELLIE
She's been up since eight. She keeps asking for someone named Theodore.

Theo stares at her. His eyes slide to the name tag.

THEO
That's my name.

ELLIE
I know.

She stands and leads him down the corridor.

INT. ALDER HILL - INGRID'S ROOM - NIGHT

Ingrid stands at the window in a winter coat and a hat, a handbag on her arm. The bed behind her is made. She does not turn around.

INGRID
He's coming up the lane. I saw him from the window.

THEO
Who is, Mom?

INGRID
Theodore.

THEO
That's me. I'm right here.

Ingrid turns. Her eyes are steady.

INGRID
No. You're Theo. Your father saw to that.

She takes Theo's sleeve in both hands.

INGRID (CONT'D)
Don't let him finish.

THEO
Finish what?

INGRID
The sentence.

She opens her handbag and takes out a brass key tied to a faded blue ribbon. She presses it into Theo's palm and closes his fingers over it.

INGRID (CONT'D)
Under the stairs. Burn it.

THEO
Burn what, Mom?

Ingrid's hands loosen on his sleeve. She touches the brim of her hat.

INGRID
Is it Thursday?

Ellie stands in the doorway. She looks at the key in Theo's fist.

ELLIE
She's held that key every night since I started here.

THEO
What does it open?

ELLIE
Ask the house.

THEO
You know what's in there.

ELLIE
Tonight, Mr. Lindqvist. Not tomorrow.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - HALL - NIGHT

The hall light is on. A steel hasp and a brass padlock hold the cellar door shut. The door sits an inch deeper in its doorway than the others.

Theo fits the key into the padlock. It turns. The hasp swings free.

He opens the door. Cold air comes up from the dark. He finds a pull-chain inside the door and tugs it. A bare bulb lights stone steps going down.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - CELLAR - NIGHT

Fourteen stone steps. A slate floor. A black iron boiler with a blue pilot flame. Shelves of dusty canning jars.

Theo reaches the bottom. Under the stairs sits a Danish butter-cookie tin, furred with dust.

He kneels and lifts the lid. Inside: a folded yellow dress printed with ducks, and a green cloth notebook. On the cover: THE MARGIN. BY THEODORE LINDQVIST. PRIVATE.

He opens the notebook. Pages of a child's pencil handwriting. In every margin, a second hand in pencil, slanted, quick:

!!
go on
what's behind the door??
best part so far

Theo's lips move over the notes. He turns to the last written page. The child's handwriting stops mid-line.

Theodore reached into the black water
and took her hand, and

The bulb flickers. It dims to orange and swings on its chain.

The blue pilot flame behind the boiler flares white.

A tall figure stands behind the boiler. Water streams from its hands and sleeves. Its face stays in the dark.

Theo steps back. His heel hits the stair.

THEO
Tomas?

The figure steps forward. A wet bare footprint forms on the slate under each foot. It raises both arms.

Theo raises the notebook between them. A wet hand closes on his wrist. Theo gasps.

The figure takes the notebook from him with its other hand and holds it open at the inside of the back cover. In pencil, in the same slanted hand as the margins:

T.A. - CHIEF READER

Water drips onto the page. The pencil does not run.

The figure pushes the notebook back into Theo's hands. Wet fingers press a small, hard object into his palm and fold his fingers closed over it.

Theo wrenches free and takes the stairs two at a time, the notebook against his chest.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - HALL - NIGHT

Theo bursts through the cellar door, slams it, shoves the hasp across, and snaps the padlock shut. He leans his whole weight on the door.

On the other side: the scratch of a pencil.

He shoves his closed fist into his coat pocket. It comes out open and empty.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

Theo sits at the table with the notebook and the laptop. His hands shake. A wet ring circles his wrist.

The clock reads 11:50. He opens the laptop to the pages he typed and lays the notebook beside it. He does not open the notebook.

THEO
These are mine.

He reads aloud, low and hard.

THEO (CONT'D)
"I carried her up the slate on my back. Her lips were blue."

The table slides away from him across the linoleum. His chair does not move. The table is six feet away.

THEO (CONT'D)
"Her hair was a rope of black water."

Ten feet. The back door slides away with it. The walls lean outward; the floor stretches between Theo and the table.

THEO (CONT'D)
"I put my mouth over hers and blew."

His voice sounds farther away with each line. A thread of water runs from the corner of his mouth. He keeps reading. The table is twenty feet away.

THEO (CONT'D)
"She coughed the whole pond out of her and into my--"

He coughs. Water pours from his mouth onto his shirt, onto the floor. He gasps. No air comes. He pitches out of the chair.

The table slams back into place. Dishes rattle.

Bare feet pound down the stairs. June runs in, barefoot in a long T-shirt, and drops to her knees. She rolls Theo onto his side and hits his back with the heel of her hand.

JUNE
Dad. Dad!

Water gushes from his mouth. A chip of gray slate the size of a thumbnail lands in the puddle.

Theo drags in a breath. Coughs again. Breathes.

JUNE (CONT'D)
I'm calling Mom.

THEO
No.

JUNE
I'm calling her.

INT. NYPL CONSERVATION LAB - DAY

A long steel table under bright lamps. Two cream pages lie under glass. A microscope, a UV lamp, a jar of white gloves.

Mara sits in front of a laptop, gloves on, a loupe around her neck. On her screen: Theo and June at the kitchen table.

Theo's shirt collar is damp. A faint blue tinge at the corners of his mouth.

MARA
The front is iron-gall ink with something added. Iron-gall dries in an hour. This is still wet.

THEO
Mara.

MARA
The back is pencil. A boy's cursive, slanted right, pressed hard enough to leave a groove. I can see it. I cannot photograph it.

She holds up her phone. On its screen, a photograph of page two's back: blank cream paper.

MARA (CONT'D)
Every photograph comes out like this. Watch.

She aims the phone at the page and taps. The new photograph shows blank cream paper.

MARA (CONT'D)
And I can't read it. I can see letters. When I focus on the words, they're somewhere else.

THEO
What does that mean?

MARA
I don't know. Here is what I do know.

She holds a sheet of paper up to the screen: a grid of photographs of Theo's forearm, each labeled with a date.

MARA (CONT'D)
I matched the graphite against a hardness scale. When I took them it was a 4B. Last night, an HB. This morning, a 2H.

She taps the first photograph, a wrist with one line. Then the last: a forearm with four.

MARA (CONT'D)
Each time the writing on you grows, the pencil on my pages gets lighter.

JUNE
Dad. Show her.

Theo pulls up his sleeve to show the screen. Four lines of ink run from wrist to elbow.

MARA
You're writing over someone.

THEO
It's my handwriting.

MARA
The front is. The back isn't yours.

THEO
Then whose?

MARA
I don't know. Stop copying them.

THEO
I can't.

MARA
Can't, or won't?

THEO
I'm writing, Mara. I haven't written in eight years.

MARA
That isn't writing. I don't know what that is.

She looks at June, then back at Theo.

MARA (CONT'D)
I'll be back Saturday. Don't read anything aloud.

THEO
Why would I read it aloud?

MARA
June says you were reading when you drowned in your kitchen.

Theo looks at June. June looks at the table.

INT. WALTER PRUITT'S COTTAGE - STUDY - DAY

A low room with a desk, an old typewriter, a window onto the quarry road. Floor-to-ceiling shelves hold forty-one books, each by a different famous name.

Walter opens the door and looks at Theo's mouth.

WALTER
You've been reading aloud.

THEO
How do you--

WALTER
Your lips are blue.

He steps back and lets Theo in. A framed photograph stands on the desk: a woman in a wool coat on a station platform.

Theo pushes up his sleeve and shows him the arm. Walter takes his time reading it.

WALTER (CONT'D)
How many pages have you copied?

THEO
Forty.

WALTER
You signed anything?

THEO
No.

WALTER
Good. That's something.

He rolls up his own left sleeve. On the inside of his forearm, faded to pale blue, four words in a neat hand:

I DID NOT KNOW

THEO
What is that?

WALTER
My senator. 1991. Very decent man, by his own account. I wrote his memoir. Six weeks. He told me what he'd done and what he hadn't, and I typed it as he told it, and the words came up on my arm.

THEO
What did it say?

WALTER
That. "I did not know." About a night in a hospital parking lot.

THEO
Did he know?

WALTER
He knew. He signed the last page and shook my hand.

He pulls his sleeve down.

THEO
I thought it was a ghost.

WALTER
A ghost is what's left of someone who stopped. This is something else. I've never known the word. Only what it does.

WALTER (CONT'D)
The man I'd been writing for stopped being the man I'd met. He got warmer. Funnier. His wife wept
(MORE)

WALTER (CONT'D)
when she told me he'd been a changed man for thirty years.

THEO
What happened to the old one?

WALTER
I've been waiting thirty-four years for somebody to tell me.

He lifts the photograph of the woman and holds it out.

WALTER (CONT'D)
My mother. I'm told. I can't remember being seven. I remember what I wrote about other men's sevens.

He sets it down.

WALTER (CONT'D)
Don't copy. Don't read it aloud. Don't sign. Those are the rules, and I only know them from breaking them.

THEO
The envelope was addressed to Theodore.

Theo takes the envelope from his coat. Walter reads the name. He sits down.

WALTER
That's yours.

THEO
Nobody's used it since I was ten.

WALTER
People don't throw away their names, Theo. They leave them somewhere. And whatever you leave long enough starts answering to it.

THEO
Mara says there's writing on the back of the pages. She can't read it.

WALTER
I had one like that. Forty years in a drawer. I never turned it over.
(MORE)

WALTER (CONT'D)
The paper went blank every time I tried.

He looks at Theo.

WALTER (CONT'D)
A page has two sides. The one you wrote and the one that held it. Whoever's holding yours has been pressing hard.

THEO
What do I do?

WALTER
Don't write tonight.

THEO
I can't not.

Walter takes a pen from the desk and puts it in Theo's hand.

WALTER
Then tell somebody something true. Out loud. Start small. It costs you something. It costs him more. He copies lies beautifully. He can't copy that.

THEO
True about what?

WALTER
You'll know it when you've said it.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - BATHROOM - NIGHT

A clawfoot tub, a pedestal sink, a medicine cabinet with a mirrored door. One bare bulb.

A legal pad and Walter's pen lie on the closed toilet lid.

Theo stands at the sink with his shirt off. Lines of brown-black handwriting cover his left arm and run across his ribs.

He scrubs the ribs with a nailbrush. The ink does not lighten.

He turns on the hot tap. Steam fogs the mirror.

THEO
I'm tired. I'm afraid.

Nothing changes on his skin. He wipes the glass with his palm.

His reflection does not wipe the glass. It stands with its hands at its sides. Clean-shaven, hair dry and combed, a pressed white shirt. It watches Theo.

Theo backs into the tub's edge.

THEODORE
That's not what he meant.

His voice is Theo's, a half step warmer.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
You told the old man I was a ghost.

THEO
Get away from me.

THEODORE
I haven't moved. You're the one scrubbing a sentence you wrote.

THEO
I didn't write it.

THEODORE
You wrote forty pages. Your daughter thinks you're a hero. Your editor cried. Look at you. You're writing again.

THEO
Because of you.

THEODORE
Because you finally listened.

Theo grips the sink.

THEO
Who are you?

THEODORE
You know my name. You stopped saying it when you were ten.

THEO
Theodore.

THEODORE
Thank you. Nobody's said it to me in thirty-eight years.

THEO
What do you want?

THEODORE
I want to tell you what happened. You've never known. Don't you want to know?

THEO
I was home.

THEODORE
Say it like you believe it.

Theo opens his mouth. No sound comes.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
That's what I thought.

Theo sits on the edge of the tub. In the glass, the reflection sits too.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
Your daughter looked at you over a bowl of cereal the way she did when she was four. Do you remember that look?

THEO
Yes.

THEODORE
No. You were writing.

Theo covers his face with his hands.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
I'm not asking you to lie. I'm asking you to let somebody be happy.

THEO
There's something in the cellar. It grabbed me.

THEODORE
I know. It's followed you since the diner. It isn't your friend. It's a bookkeeping error.

THEO
What is it?

THEODORE
Something unpaid. I can make it stop.

THEO
How?

THEODORE
One line. Everyone wants it. Nell wants it. Your mother wants it. You want it.

Theo lowers his hands.

THEO
My mother said don't let you finish.

THEODORE
She read me every night for years, Theo. Ask her what she wished.

The reflection steps to the glass and breathes on it. Fog spreads. A finger writes in the fog:

and she lived

Theo's right hand picks up Walter's pen from the toilet lid. It writes on the pad: and she lived.

Theo grips his right wrist with his left hand. The right hand keeps writing the same words, again, again, down the page.

A new line of ink surfaces along his collarbone:

and she lived

The pen drops. Theo stares at the page. He looks up.

The reflection smiles at him.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
Thank you.

The bulb warms to amber. Under the floor, one long stroke of a pencil.

EXT. QUARRY TURNOUT - MORNING

Sun on wet gravel. The station wagon sits at the turnout, engine off. Theo stands at the granite slab with his left sleeve rolled down over the ink.

The inscription: TOMAS ARVIDSEN. 1974 - 1987. HE REACHED FOR HER. The plastic flowers are bleached white. A mason jar of fresh marigolds stands at the base.

Theo kneels. He traces the letters of the name with two fingers.

Gray dust sifts from under his fingertips. The letters of TOMAS ARVIDSEN crumble and slide down the face of the slab. The wind carries the dust away.

Theo snatches his hand back. His fingertips are gray.

New letters cut themselves into the granite, one stroke at a time, chips of stone flying from the surface:

THEODORE LINDQVIST
AUGUST 14, 1987
HE REACHED FOR HER

The chips settle on the gravel. The stone is whole, sharp-edged, new.

Theo stands and backs away.

A wheelbarrow rattles up the path. A SEXTON (60s) in a town maintenance vest, a bag of mulch in the barrow, stops beside Theo.

SEXTON
Morning, Mr. Lindqvist.

THEO
What happened to the name?

SEXTON
Which name?

THEO
Tomas. Tomas Arvidsen. It was right there.

SEXTON
Who's Tomas?

THEO
The boy who drowned.

SEXTON
Nobody drowned, Mr. Lindqvist. You pulled her out.

He lays a hand on the granite.

SEXTON (CONT'D)
I was here the day they set this. Whole town was. You wouldn't let go of her hand.

Theo looks at the jar of marigolds.

THEO
Somebody leaves flowers.

SEXTON
Every August. Never did figure out who.

The sexton holds out his hand.

SEXTON (CONT'D)
My daughter was in your sister's class. I never said thank you.

Theo looks at the hand. At the stone. He shakes it.

INT. SLATE DINER - NIGHT

Every booth is full. A hand-lettered banner hangs over the counter: WELCOME HOME, THEO. A pie sits on every table.

Theo and June stand in the doorway. The room applauds. June's face lights up. She tugs his sleeve.

JUNE
Dad. They made a banner.

A MAN (50s) pumps Theo's hand.

MAN
I was at the quarry that day. They had to pry your fingers off her hand.

A WOMAN (60s) takes Theo's wrist and turns it to the light, reading the ink.

WOMAN
I always loved this. "I reached." How old were you when you got it?

THEO
I--

WOMAN
Sixteen. You told me once. Your father was furious.

She pats his arm and moves on. The people nearby glance at the ink on his wrist and nod, unbothered.

June scans the room.

JUNE
Where's Walter?

THEO
Home.

JUNE
He should be here. He'd love this.

The WAITRESS (60s) sets a slice of pie in front of Theo.

WAITRESS
On the house, hero.

In the booth by the door sits Ellie in a raincoat, a cup of coffee in front of her. She is not clapping. She is looking at Theo.

His eyes find her. Her face blurs. His eyes slide to her cup, her raincoat, the door.

Ellie stands, leaves a bill under her saucer, and walks toward the exit. She stops beside Theo.

ELLIE
Funny. I don't remember it that way.

THEO
You were there?

ELLIE
I was.

She goes out. The door closes behind her. The room goes on applauding.

INT. SLATE DINER - MORNING

Theo sits alone at the counter with a coffee. The diner is full again.

Every mug in the room is filled to the same line, a finger below the rim. The waitress pours Theo's cup. The coffee stops at the line.

A MAN in one booth says, "Welcome home, Theo." A second man in another booth says it at the same moment, in the same voice. They look at each other and smile.

The clock over the register reads 7:15.

Theo drinks his coffee and sets the cup down. It is full to the line.

A man at the end of the counter lifts his mug and drinks. The level does not drop. He sets it down and lifts it again.

The waitress says "Welcome home, hon" to a customer. She says it to the next customer with the same words, the same pitch, the same smile.

Theo looks at the clock. It reads 7:15.

Everyone in the diner turns toward him at once. They speak in one voice.

DINERS
Everything okay, Theo?

Theo drops a bill on the counter and backs out.

INT. STATION WAGON - PARKED - DAY

Theo slams the door and grips the wheel. His breath fogs the windshield.

In the rearview mirror, a man sits in the back seat.

THEODORE (47) wears a pressed white shirt. Theo's face, clean-shaven, hair dry and combed. No shadow falls on the seat beside him.

THEODORE
Good morning.

Theo does not turn around.

THEO
What did you do to them?

THEODORE
Nothing. They remember. Remembering together is easier. Look how happy they are.

THEO
The clock stopped.

THEODORE
Time is a draft too. Everything gets edited.

THEO
I want it back the way it was.

THEODORE
Was it good? Your mother in a home. Your wife in another city. Your daughter asking you to read eleven pages.

THEO
Don't.

THEODORE
I wrote a better one. Nobody's lonely in it.

Theo turns in his seat at last. Theodore smiles at him.

THEO
Where is he?

THEODORE
Who?

THEO
Tomas.

Theodore's smile holds. His throat works. He opens his mouth. Nothing comes out.

THEODORE
That--

He swallows.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
The neighbor's boy.

THEO
Say his name.

THEODORE
The boy from down the road.

THEO
His name.

Theodore breathes in through his nose. The smile stays on his face.

THEODORE
I don't need it.

THEO
You can't say it.

THEODORE
I can say anything. I choose not to.

THEO
Why can't you say it?

THEODORE
Why do you keep asking about the wet one? The other night he had his hands on you in the cellar. Did you ask what he wants?

THEO
What does he want?

THEODORE
To keep you from being happy.

Theo faces front. His hands shake on the wheel.

THEO
I won't sign anything.

THEODORE
Nobody's asking you to sign. You've typed forty pages. You're nearly home.

Theo shuts his eyes.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
I'll be there for June. I always will.

Theo opens his eyes. The back seat is empty. The cushion holds no dent.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

The lamp is on. The table is set for dinner: two bowls of spaghetti, steaming.

June sits at one place. At the head of the table, in Theo's chair, sits Theodore, sleeves rolled, a napkin in his lap, his chin on his hand. He listens to June.

Theo stands in the doorway.

JUNE
--and then the lighthouse keeper finds out the whole crew is a ghost, and he has to decide whether to tell them.

THEODORE
Does he?

JUNE
That's chapter five. I haven't decided.

THEODORE
I'd tell them. Eventually. Gently.

June looks up at Theo.

JUNE
Theo, you can sit there.

She points at the foot of the table. A third place is set. The bowl is cold, a skin on the sauce.

THEO
Theo?

JUNE
Dad made spaghetti.

Theodore smiles at Theo across the table.

THEODORE
Sit. There's plenty.

Theo sits. He picks up his fork.

JUNE
Can I read you my story?

THEO
I'd love that. In a minute.

June's smile drops. She looks at her plate. Theodore lays his napkin on the table.

THEODORE
Read it to me.

June pulls her laptop toward her. She turns to Theodore and reads, her face lit.

JUNE
"Chapter One. The lighthouse had no keeper, only a lamp that wouldn't go out."

Theo watches her. At the end of every paragraph her eyes flick to Theodore. He nods each time.

June pauses. She looks at Theo's left wrist, where his sleeve rides up over the ink.

JUNE (CONT'D)
Cool tattoo. Have you always had that?

THEO
Since when does it look like a tattoo?

JUNE
You've had it forever.

She goes back to her story.

JUNE (CONT'D)
You should listen too. Dad's listening.

THEO
I'm your dad.

JUNE
I know. You're Dad too.

She smiles at him and turns back to Theodore.

Theo stands. He carries his bowl to the counter and scrapes it into the trash. He stays at the sink with his hands on the edge.

In the black window over the sink: the lamp, the table, and June reading with her whole face lit to an empty chair.

Behind him, Theodore speaks.

THEODORE
She's reading beautifully.

EXT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - PORCH - DAY

Rain. Mara stands at the foot of the porch steps in her gray coat, no case, water running from her hair. She looks up at Theo in the doorway for a long time.

MARA
I remember a flood.

THEO
What?

MARA
The storm in October. Perry Street. The water came up the basement stairs. I remember it at my knees. I remember you carrying me out and up to the street.

THEO
That never--

MARA
I know. I remember that too.

She climbs the steps and stands in front of him.

MARA (CONT'D)
I remember you standing in the doorway at three in the morning with a glass of water, not saying anything. For years. That's the one I left.

THEO
Mara.

MARA
I remember that you were a hero and I remember that you weren't. Which one did I leave?

Theo opens his mouth. Nothing comes out.

She takes a clear plastic sleeve from her coat. Two cream pages lie inside. She puts it in his hands.

MARA (CONT'D)
The pencil on the back is gone. I can't see any of it now. I only know it was there because of the groove.

She presses the heel of her hand to her forehead.

MARA (CONT'D)
Where did we meet?

THEO
What?

MARA
A café. It was raining. I've been trying since I left. It's gone.

THEO
Café Orso.

MARA
Orso.

She says it again, her lips shaping each syllable.

MARA (CONT'D)
You spilled my tea.

THEO
You said I owed you a scone.

MARA
You still do.

A laugh breaks out of her and turns into a sob. She wipes her face with her wet sleeve.

THEO
Walter said to tell somebody something true. It costs.

MARA
Then tell me.

Theo looks at his left wrist. He says it.

THEO
I don't know what I did that day.

The line on his wrist, I reached, fades to a pale gray smear, then to nothing. Theo sways. Mara catches his elbow.

MARA
What did it cost you?

THEO
I don't know.

MARA
That's the worst part.

She keeps hold of his arm.

MARA (CONT'D)
I'm at the motel in Granville. Don't let June read it aloud.

THEO
She isn't reading it.

MARA
Theo. She's twelve and she's lonely and you left her with it. Don't let her read it aloud.

She lets go of his arm and walks back down the steps into the rain.

INT. WALTER PRUITT'S COTTAGE - STUDY - DAY

Rain on the window. The desk, the typewriter, the forty-one books. Walter sits in his chair, hands folded on his knee, his cardigan buttoned one hole off.

Theo stands in the doorway, wet.

WALTER
Come in. I was hoping you'd come.

THEO
I tried what you said. I told someone something true.

WALTER
Did it work?

THEO
A line went away. And something else did. I don't know what.

WALTER
That's how it works.

Walter looks at the shelves.

WALTER (CONT'D)
I think I'm going.

THEO
Going where?

WALTER
Out of everyone's memory. I've felt it since Tuesday. The spines look thinner every morning. I can read maybe thirty of the titles.

Theo steps to the shelves. The gilt on the nearest spine is faint.

THEO
I'll stop. I'll stop copying.

WALTER
You'll try. That's different.

He smiles.

WALTER (CONT'D)
Listen to me. It ends when the one who left it open says it truthfully. That's all I ever worked out. The one who left it open. And you have to say the name of the one it stole from.

THEO
Who did it steal from?

WALTER
A boy.

He closes his eyes.

WALTER (CONT'D)
It's a boy's name. I had it this morning.

The spines on the shelves go blank, one at a time. The titles fade first, then the gilt, then the cloth bleaches white.

Forty-one books, one after another, a white line moving down the shelves.

Walter watches them go.

WALTER (CONT'D)
Forty-one. I counted them every night.

THEO
Walter--

WALTER
I never put my name on anything. If you get to the end of it, put it somewhere.

The last spine goes white. Walter's hands lie open on his knees. His face goes pleasant and vague.

WALTER (CONT'D)
Can I help you?

THEO
Walter, it's Theo.

WALTER
Theo. I don't believe I've had the pleasure.

He stands, smiles, and holds out his hand.

Theo takes it. Walter's hand is not there.

The chair is empty. A dust sheet lies over it. The shelves are bare. Cobwebs hang from the desk lamp. A fur of dust covers the typewriter.

THEO (CONT'D)
Walter?

On the floor lies the framed photograph of the woman on the station platform, its glass cracked. Theo picks it up and turns it over. In ballpoint on the back: MOTHER, 1958.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - THEO'S CHILDHOOD BEDROOM - NIGHT

A narrow bed under a slanted ceiling. A model biplane hangs from a string. A shelf of boys' adventure novels with cracked spines.

Theo sleeps in his clothes. Pencil scratching starts: the left wall, the right wall, the ceiling, the floor, all at once.

His eyes open. The scratching stops.

Silence. Then it starts again, soft, under the bed.

He gets up and opens the door.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - UPSTAIRS HALL - NIGHT

The upstairs hall is the same hall reversed. The stairs are on the right instead of the left. The doors stand in reverse order.

The numerals on the wall clock run counterclockwise.

Theo goes down. His left hand reaches for a banister that is on his right.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - HALL - NIGHT

The ground-floor hall is reversed too: the cellar door on the right, the white door at the near end, the kitchen at the far end. The card on the cellar door reads RALLEC.

Water seeps from under the cellar door and from under the white door. It runs along the baseboards toward the kitchen.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

The stove stands on the opposite wall. The window over the sink is on the far side. The clock's numerals are mirror-written. The label on the cereal box reads backward.

June and Theodore sit at the table under the lamp. June reads from Theo's laptop. Theodore listens with his chin on his hand.

Water covers the linoleum to the soles of June's bare feet. She doesn't look down.

JUNE
"She was in the water before I understood she was in the water."

THEO
June.

She does not look up.

THEODORE
Shh. She's reading beautifully.

THEO
June! Stop.

JUNE
"I went in. I didn't decide to. It tasted of iron."

The water reaches Theo's ankles. The pencil scratching is a roar in the walls.

JUNE (CONT'D)
"I looked up at the ledge for someone to call. There was nobody on the ledge. I looked. I want that written down."

Theo wades toward the table. His legs drag.

JUNE (CONT'D)
"So I reached into the black water and took her hand, and she--"

A tall wet figure steps out of the dark behind June. A wet hand clamps over her mouth.

June's scream is muffled. Her heels kick.

Theo throws himself at the figure. His shoulder hits wet ribs. They crash into the stove. The figure's arms fly wide and water sprays across the kitchen.

Theo punches. His fist lands on a cold, wet body. It staggers and slides down the wall.

THEO
Let her go!

June staggers back from the table, hands at her mouth, coughing. She stares at Theo.

JUNE
Stop it! What are you doing?

THEO
It had its hand on your mouth!

JUNE
There's nothing there! You're not him!

THEO
Who?

JUNE
You're not Dad!

Theodore sits still. He watches Theo with his head tilted.

Theo looks at the wet figure on the floor. It sits slumped against the wall, hands open on its knees, its head bowed. It makes no move.

He looks at his daughter, her face white.

THEO
I'm not a hero.

JUNE
What?

THEO
I'm not a hero! I never saved anyone! She asked me to come see the door and I said "in a minute"! I didn't even look up!

The lights come on. The water is gone. The stove stands on its own wall again. The clock's numerals read forward.

The wet figure is gone. Theodore's chair is empty. The scratching is gone.

On Theo's forearm, the line There was nobody on the ledge fades to a gray smear, then to nothing.

June stands with her back against the refrigerator, breathing hard.

JUNE
That's the first page.

THEO
It's the only part I remember.

JUNE
Then who saved her?

Theo sits down on the floor where he stands.

THEO
I don't know.

EXT. QUARRY POND - NIGHT

A full moon. Slate shelves step down to the pond. Theo comes down the path with a flashlight and stops at the water's edge.

The pond is black and flat. The moon hangs in the sky. The water shows no moon.

Thirty feet out, a tall figure stands waist-deep, arms stretched out from its sides. Its mouth moves. No sound carries.

Theo clicks off the flashlight.

THEO
Tomas?

The figure's lips keep moving.

Theo picks up a stone and throws it. The stone enters the water without a splash or a ring.

The figure lowers one arm. It points past Theo, up the hill.

Theo turns. At the top of the slope, the kitchen window of the farmhouse glows amber.

He runs.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

Theo bursts through the back door, soaked to the knees. The kitchen is empty. Theodore's chair is empty. The lamp burns amber.

He takes the stairs three at a time and stops in the doorway of June's room. June sleeps on her side, one hand under her cheek. The window is shut.

Theo breathes. He goes back down and sits at the kitchen table. The clock reads 3:58. Rain starts at the window.

Four knocks at the back door.

Theo crosses and opens it. Ellie stands on the step in a dripping raincoat, a framed photograph held against her chest.

ELLIE
I walked from the highway.

She walks in. She sets the frame on the table, face up.

The photograph: Theo at nine squints on a slate ledge. A flat black pond lies behind him.

Beside him a five-year-old girl in a yellow dress printed with ducks grins at the lens, a front tooth missing.

ELLIE (CONT'D)
This hung in Mom's shadow box until Dad took it down. She kept it in the drawer by her bed.

THEO
Why do you have it?

ELLIE
Because it's mine.

Theo looks from the photograph to her face. Her face stays sharp. It does not blur. Her eyes match the girl's.

ELLIE (CONT'D)
I'm Nell.

Theo says nothing. His hand lies flat on the table.

ELLIE (CONT'D)
You never took my hand.

BLACK.

END OF ACT TWO